

“The Muslim leadership provided the rabid Hindu ideologues sufficient cause to instill fear into the common citizen. Whether the political Muslim leadership represented the views of the average Muslim citizen is highly doubtful. The elite political Muslim leadership constituted a class by itself and was neither responsible to, nor caring for the welfare of those they purported to champion.”

legally admissible evidence is gathered in the investigation. Though the Government says it will expedite the existing cases, it has not so far shown any sense of urgency. The CBI has so far presented eight of the 49 witnesses and plans to produce two important witnesses, both sub-inspectors in the local intelligence units of the state police. They had recorded the speeches of the accused as part of their duty.

The Congress spokesman's comments look more like a political balancing act by the party. Party spokesman Abhishek Manu Singhvi says the UPA Government has noted in its ATR that it intends to expedite the existing cases. “As per the procedure, the investigating agencies would study the report and investigate the cases further if any fresh detail was found. This could be the basis of the supplementary charge-sheet and not the Commission's report,” he adds.

Many argue that the country's experience on taking appropriate action against persons in a court of law based on inquiry commission reports has been discouraging. “A commission today serves only the purpose of the Government. The decision to take follow-up action in a court of law is left to the government. In the absence of a political will, nothing happens. People too forget it by lapse of time,” says Justice B.N. Srikrishna. He knows better. After all, he headed the Commission that probed the Mumbai riots of 1993. Though its report indicted many, no one was punished.

by Shafi Rahman

## Pilgrims But NO PROGRESS

**D**ekhiye, yeh sunder khambe aur Ram shilayen yahan taiyyar hain. Kaam poora ho gaya hai. Ram ka bhavnya mandir Ayodhya mein jaldi banega (Look at the beautiful stone pillars and bricks with the name of Sri Ram engraved on them. They are ready for the construction of grand Ram temple in Ayodhya soon),” announces a 16-year-old self-styled tour guide, Suraj Pandey, before hundreds of pilgrims who had come to Ayodhya from Satara in Maharashtra. As soon as Pandey, perched on a pillar, completes his announcements and disembarks, the pilgrims bow before the pillars in the Sri Ram Janmabhoomi Mandir Nirman Karyashala, touch the engraved words of Jai Sri Ram on them as if they were standing before Lord Ram and touching his feet.

The construction work in the Ram Janaki workshop in the heart of Ayodhya, and about eight-km away from the disputed birthplace of Lord Ram, had come to a standstill

last year, officially, for shortage of funds, unofficially because its financier—the VHP—sees no hope for the construction of a Ram temple at Ayodhya in the near future. While the protracted battle is still going on in the courts and outside, 106 of the required 212 pillars are ready and the floor tiles completed. Every pillar has carvings of Hindu Gods and Goddesses. Thousands of Sri Ram shilas are stacked on one side and on the other, a model of the proposed temple to show pilgrims what the VHP plans.

For visiting religious tourists or the domiciles of this temple town, and the saffron-clad sadhus and saints, the

PILLARS AND FLOOR TILES ARE READY BUT THE TEMPLE REMAINS A CASTLE IN THE AIR



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Liberhan Commission recommendations are not an issue because they feel confident that no force on earth can stop a temple of Ram in his birthplace. “Will Muslims compromise on Mecca or Medina? A grand temple will be constructed, come what may,” reiterates Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, who heads the Sri Ram Janmabhoomi Nyas. But how long will he wait? Das has a ready answer: “Didn't we fight more than 500 years for the Independence of the country from the clutches of Mughals and then Britishers?”

There is, however, a difference. In Ayodhya, life is normal as usual except for extra security arrangements because of the heat raised over the Liberhan report in Delhi. That is actually a preventive measure adopted every year before December 6, the day when the disputed structure was razed to the ground by frenzied kar sevaks. The reports may have resurrected the ghost of the past, but the present reality in Ayodhya is very much status quo. by Subhash Mishra